Upside Down Kingdom 2

Week 5 — 10/27/26

Matthew 5:38–48

Beatitudes 5:3–12	3 Hope Images 5:13–16	**Antitheses 5:17–48**	Righteous Practices 6:1–20	Parallel Discourses 6:21–7:12	3 Warning Images 7:13–27

REVIEW OF LAST WEEK

- At the heart of adultery is "I see, I desire, I take" covetousness; participating in the chain (e.g. lust) ignore what God already gives us.
- To be blasé about your covenant with your spouse (e.g. via a divorce out of selfishness) is to be blasé about your covenant with God.
- Oaths are designed to reflect God's character who makes good on promises; when abused they reflect our low regard towards God.

PASSAGE OF THE WEEK (PT.1) (NET)

a **38** You have heard that it was said,
b 'An eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth.'
a' **39** But I say to you,
b' do not resist the evildoer.
a But whoever strikes you on the right cheek,
b turn the other to him as well
a' **40** And if someone wants to sue you and take your tunic,
b' let him have your coat also.
a'' **41** And if anyone forces you to go one mile,
b'' go with him two.
42 Give to the one who asks you,
and do not reject the one who wants to borrow from you.

INDIVIDUALS' TRANSLATIONS

Tim Mackie

38 You have heard that it was said,
"An eye in recompense for (anti) an eye,
and a tooth in recompense for (anti) a tooth."
39 And I say to you,
do not resist-in-kind (anti) an evil person.
But whoever slaps you on your right cheek,
turn the other to him also.
40 and to the one who wants to sue you and take your shirt,
release to him also your coat,
41 and whoever forces you to go one mile,
go with him two.
42 To the one who asks of you,
give,
And to the one who wants to borrow from you,
don't turn away.

R.T. France

38 You have heard that it was said, 'Eye for eye and tooth for tooth.' **39** But I tell you: do not resist a bad person, but instead if anyone slaps you on the right cheek, turn the other cheek to them as well; **40** and if anyone wants to take you to court to get your shirt, let them have your coat as well; **41** and if anyone dragoons you as a porter for one mile, go with them for two miles. **42** Give to someone who asks you, and don't turn a cold shoulder to someone who wants to borrow from you.

COMMENTARY QUOTES

Often the right(eous) thing to do is to be wronged by another; often the just thing to do is not to seek one's own justice. In this we hear again the echoes of the topsy-turvy, eschatological virtue vision of the Beatitudes (5:3–12). The place of flourishing is, unexpectedly and ironically, the place of poverty of spirit, mourning, meekness, hunger and thirst, mercifulness, purity of heart, peacemaking, and suffering for righteousness' sake.
...
A literal reading of these verses cannot give us the wisdom needed for decision making in all kinds of real-life situations that do indeed require the resistance of evil. Instead, this strong language shocks and jolts us into seeing the situation in a new way...That is, Jesus's teachings are a call to a way of being in the world that teaches us to look inward and become a different kind of people, a vision of virtue. A radical reorientation to our thinking often requires a hyperbolic speech (cf. the parables).

— Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing, p.197*

Here more than anywhere in this section we need to remind ourselves that Jesus' aim is not to establish a new and more demanding set of rules to supplant those of the scribes and Pharisees. It is to establish a "greater righteousness," a different understanding of how we should live as the people of God, an alternative set of values...instead of therefore dismissing Jesus' teaching as starry-eyed utopianism, a proper response to this challenging section is to ask in what practical ways Jesus' radical principles *can* be set to work in our very different world.
...
But none of these illustrations sets out a prudential maxim; all of them (like the Beatitudes) challenge us to unnatural behavior, and all must seem crazy to a secular world (and indeed have been denounced as such). The point they are making is that in the kingdom of heaven self-interest does not rule, and even our legal rights and legitimate expectations may have to give way to the interests of others.

— R.T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew, pp.217–218, 220, 222*

OLD TESTAMENT Isaiah 50:4–9 (NASB)

[Relevance: The one who refuses to retaliate entrusts his cause to God, who alone vindicates.]

> The Lord God has given Me the tongue of disciples,
> So that I may know how to sustain the weary one with a word.
> He awakens Me morning by morning,
> He awakens My ear to listen as a disciple.
> The Lord God has opened My ear,
> And I was not disobedient,
> Nor did I turn back.
> I gave My back to those who strike Me,
> And My cheeks to those who pull out My beard;
> I did not hide My face from insults and spitting.
> For the Lord God helps Me,
> Therefore, I am not disgraced;
> Therefore, I have made My face like flint,
> And I know that I will not be ashamed.
> He who vindicates Me is near;
> Who will contend with Me?
> Let us stand up to each other.
> Who has a case against Me?
> Let him approach Me.
> Behold, the Lord God helps Me;
> Who is he who condemns Me?
> Behold, they will all wear out like a garment;
> A moth will eat them.

CHALLENGING QUESTIONS

1. Is the main challenge from Jesus that society has turned a legal principle to a social one? Or more personal?
2. What aspects of the human heart are in discussion here?
3. Are these examples particularly difficult to follow without the oppressive social background of Roman-occupied Judea?
4. Do these examples have a common thread beyond doing more than what is asked/demanded/imposed?
5. What about not-resisting-evil(doers) actually displays the kingdom of heaven?

JOURNAL NOTES	
38 You have heard that it was said, 'An eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth.' **39** But I say to you, Do not resist the one who is evil. But if anyone slaps you on the right cheek, turn to him the other also. **40** And if anyone would sue you and take your tunic, let him have your cloak as well. **41** And if anyone forces you to go one mile, go with him two miles. **42** Give to the one who begs from you, and do not refuse the one who would borrow from you. (ESV)	

PASSAGE OF THE WEEK (PT.2) (NET)

a **43** You have heard that it was said,
b ‘Love your neighbor’ and ‘hate your enemy.’
a’ **44** But I say to you,
b’ love your enemy and pray for those who persecute you,
c **45** so that you may be like your Father in heaven,
d since he causes the sun to rise on the evil and the good,
d’ and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.
a **46** For if you love those who love you,
b what reward do you have?
c Even the tax collectors do the same, don’t they?
a’ **47** And if you only greet your brothers,
b’ what more do you do?
c’ Even the Gentiles do the same, don’t they?
★ **48** So then, be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.

INDIVIDUALS’ TRANSLATIONS

Tim Mackie

43 **You have heard that it was said**,
“You shall love your neighbor
and hate your enemy.”
44 **But I say to you,**
love your enemies
and pray for those who persecute you,
45 so that you may be children of your Father who is in the skies;
for he causes his sun to rise on the evil and the good,
and he sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous
46 For if you love those who love you,
what reward do you have?
Do not even the tax collectors do the same?
47 And if you greet only your brothers,
what more are you doing than others?
Do not even the nations do the same?
48 Therefore you are to be whole/complete,
as your Father in the skies is whole/complete.

Jonathan Pennington

43 You have heard that it was said, “Love your neighbor and hate your enemy.” **44** And I say to you, love your enemy and pray for those who persecute you **45** in order that you may be the children of your Father in heaven, who shines the sun on both evil and good people and brings rain to both the righteous and unrighteous. **46** For if you only love the ones who love you, what reward will you have? Do not even tax collectors do that? **47** And if you only love your brothers and sisters, how are you doing more righteousness? Do not even gentiles do that? **48** Therefore, you shall be whole as your heavenly Father is whole.

COMMENTARY QUOTES

To love those who do not love you is not offered as a piece of pragmatic wisdom, but as a reflection of the character of God himself (v.45). ...The purpose of the whole of the discourse so far has not been to provide a suitable ethic for getting along alright in the world but to challenge those who have accepted the demands of the kingdom of heaven to live up to their commitment by being different from other people. The rhetorical questions of vv. 46–47 therefore sum up the thrust of all these examples of the greater righteousness: it is to live on a level above that of ordinary decent people, to draw your standards of conduct not from what everyone else is doing, but from your heavenly Father. This teaching of Jesus on the love of enemies formed one of the most distinctive traits of the early Christian movement.
...
The disciple’s lifestyle is to be different from other people’s in that it draws its inspiration not from the norms of society but from the character of God. Even the God-given law had been accommodated to a practical ethical code with which Jewish society had come to feel comfortable, but Jesus is demanding a different approach, not via laws read as simply rules of conduct but rather by looking behind those laws to the mind and character of God himself. Whereas any definable set of rules could, in principle, be fully kept, the demand of the kingdom of heaven has no such limit — or rather its limit is perfection, the perfection of God himself. ... It is thus a suitable term to sum up the “greater righteousness” of v.20, a righteousness which is demanded not only from an upper echelon of spiritual elites but from all who belong to the kingdom of God. It is in the promotion of this standard of perfection, going far beyond the literal requirements of the OT law, that Jesus “fulfills” it.

— R.T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew, pp.224, 228–229*

As with the six exegeses of Torah, Jesus is *not* giving a new law of super-ethics and *more* requirements to enter God’s kingdom—“adultery was bad before; now adultery *and* lust are bad,” and so on. Rather, the same Jesus who says his yoke is easy and his burden is light (11:28–30) is emphasizing the internal over the external and proclaiming that God sees and cares about who people are at the heart level. To say that disciples must be *teleios* as God is *teleios* is to say that they must be whole or virtuous—singular in who they are—not one thing on the outside but another on the inside. The call to *teleios*-ity in 5:48 and throughout the Sermon is the same call to holiness that we see throughout the Old Testament (and the rest of the New Testament)—not moral perfection but having wholehearted orientation toward God. Indeed, 5:48 is clearly a reappropriation of (or intertexual twist on) the great holiness command from Lev. 19:2 and 20:26 (“Be holy, as I am holy”), with the likely influence of Deut. 18:13 as well. I believe Matthew/Jesus has chosen to restate Lev. 20:26 in terms of *teleios*-ity because “holiness” in the Pharisees’ world had come to mean primarily *external* matters of purity and behavior. The word “holy” was too loaded with connotations to quote Lev. 20:26 directly, so he playfully but profoundly swaps out *hagios* (holy) for *teleios* (whole). As in 5:17–47, Jesus is giving a reappropriated, clear exposition of the true intent of the Law. The call to “holiness” in Lev. 19:2 and 20:26 is now properly explicated—as was its true intent always—as a call to “wholeness,” or, in short, Godward virtue. At the same time, by emphasizing wholeness Jesus is showing that a casuistic approach to God (through obedience to Torah) will not produce the greater righteousness because it is all too possible to refrain from adultery and still lust, to refrain from murder and still hate. Thus, to obtain *teleios*-ity one must have something deeper, a purity of heart (Matt. 5:8) and poverty of spirit (5:3), and so on.

— Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing, p.204–205*

OLD TESTAMENT Exodus 23:1–9 (NASB)

[Relevance: Faithfulness to God is proven toward the enemy and the stranger, because God's justice and goodness do not ask who deserves them.]

> You shall not give a false report; do not join your hand with a wicked person to be a malicious witness. You shall not follow the crowd in doing evil, nor shall you testify in a dispute so as to join together with a crowd in order to pervert justice; nor shall you show favor to a poor person in his dispute.
>
> If you encounter your enemy's ox or his donkey wandering away, you must return it to him. If you see the donkey of one who hates you lying helpless under its load, you shall not leave it helpless for its owner; you must arrange the load with him.
>
> You shall not pervert the justice due to your needy brother in his dispute. Keep far from a false charge, and do not kill the innocent or the righteous, for I will not acquit the guilty.
>
> You shall not take a bribe, for a bribe blinds the clear-sighted and subverts the cause of the just.
>
> You shall not oppress a stranger, since you yourselves know the feelings of a stranger, for you also were strangers in the land of Egypt.

CHALLENGING QUESTIONS

1. What is the "heart-issue failure" of failing to love your enemy?
2. (v. 44) Why the command to pray? Is loving enemies not already difficult enough? What does it add?
3. Is love what ultimately sets apart disciples of Christ in the world?
4. What does it mean to "be perfect"?
5. Is persecution a necessary component to this discipleship? To what end/purpose/telos? (cf. 1 Peter)

JOURNAL NOTES

43 You have heard that it was said, 'You shall love your neighbor and hate your enemy.' **44** But I say to you, Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, **45** so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven. For he makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust. **46** For if you love those who love you, what reward do you have? Do not even the tax collectors do the same? **47** And if you greet only your brothers, what more are you doing than others? Do not even the Gentiles do the same? **48** You therefore must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect. (ESV)